

IDEAS

BOREDOM IS THE PRICE WE PAY FOR MEANING

When I became a father, I was forced to reckon with the emotion that
consumed my days.

By Daniel Smith

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Illustration by Jon Han

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SHARE  SAVE 

WHEN MY FIRST CHILD WAS BORN, I discovered, as many new parents do, that my love for her was more profound than I could have anticipated. I had friends and relatives for whom I was willing to die. For my daughter, so visceral was my love, so instantaneous and complete, I knew I would kill.

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pleasure in me that I'd felt driven to expand the scope of existence itself. Experience

was too wonderful to hoard, so I had a child. The irony was painful in that, seemingly overnight, the very things that most enlivened and sustained me—reading, watching movies, seeing friends, making love, sitting quietly by myself—were crowded out by a child whose needs absorbed nearly all of my energy and time. From a life of freedom and agency I had entered a life of constriction and tension, of white-noise machines, parenting manuals, and fatigue.

No one had warned me! Or had they? At 4 a.m. one morning, between shifts of bouncing my colicky daughter, [a line from the writer Nora Johnson](#) returned to me. Being a parent, Johnson insisted, isn't about nobility or beauty, pride or pleasure. Rather, it is "the simple, nerve-wracking, mindless, battering-ram process of trying to teach a savage to use a fork." I remembered this line the way Julius Caesar, his blood pooling on the senatorial marble, must have remembered, "Beware the ides of March."

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Daniel Smith is a psychotherapist and the author, most recently, of *Hard Feelings: Finding the Wisdom in Our Darkest Emotions*.

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